

“THE WORKERS’ AND PEASANTS’ GOVERNMENT... PROPOSES TO ALL WARRING PEOPLES... NEGOTIATIONS LEADING TO A JUST, DEMOCRATIC PEACE.”

Lenin, November 8, 1917



These British Mark IV tanks are transported to the Cambrai offensive. They carry bundles of wood to fill the trenches, so that they can drive across them.

The British army remained committed to an offensive strategy. In the second half of the year, General Douglas Haig (1856–1951) began a **new push at Ypres** (see pp.344–345), hoping to break through to the ports where German U-boats were based. Haig’s offensive ran into persistent bad weather that reduced the battlefield to a sea of mud. The offensive persisted into November, until British and Canadian troops reached **Passchendaele**, the village that finally gave its name to the battle.

The mud in Flanders rendered tanks, an increasingly important element of British weaponry,

3 THE NUMBER OF CREW THAT FLEW AND OPERATED A GERMAN GOTHIA BOMBER

inoperative. On harder ground at **Cambrai** in November, massed tanks helped British forces advance 4 miles (6 km) in one day—three times the distance achieved at Passchendaele in three months. Any celebrations were premature, however, as a German counterattack soon retook most of the lost ground.

The long stalemate between Italy and Austria-Hungary ended when German troops were transferred to the Italian front in October. At the **Battle of Caporetto**, an Austro-German offensive drove Italian forces into retreat. A line was stabilized in November behind the Piave River, just 19 miles (30 km) from Venice (see p.345).

From June, civilians living in Paris and London were subjected to sporadic **air attacks by German**

Gotha bombers and even larger “R-planes.” These fixed-wing aircraft were faster and more difficult to shoot down than the German airships (see 1915), although defense by anti-aircraft guns and fighter aircraft soon forced them to attack exclusively by night. Physical damage and casualties were not great, but the psychological impact of these raids was considerable, as citizens were driven to hide underground in cellars and subway stations.

In all combatant countries war weariness and worsening conditions made it hard for governments to maintain solidarity. Food shortages and socialist sentiments, excited by the revolutionary uprising in Russia, led to widespread **strike action in German factories**. The German Reichstag (parliament) passed a resolution calling for peace negotiations in July, but it had no control over the military-dominated German government.

In France, scandals and strikes rocked the political system through the summer and fall, but the appointment of the fiercely pro-war Georges Clemenceau (1841–1929) as prime minister in November stiffened resolve.

Dawn breaks at Passchendaele

Dead and wounded soldiers lie in the muddy desolation of the battlefield in the Ypres salient, where the battle of Passchendaele was fought.



The British royal family, meanwhile, found it prudent to change its name from the Germanic Saxe-Coburg and Gotha to Windsor.

The British public was cheered in December by the **capture of Jerusalem from Turkey**. This military success gave practical importance to the previous month’s **Balfour Declaration**, which expressed British government support for Zionist aspirations to “a national home for the Jewish people in Palestine.” Britain’s Arab allies, fighting alongside the British army against the Turks, had not been consulted.

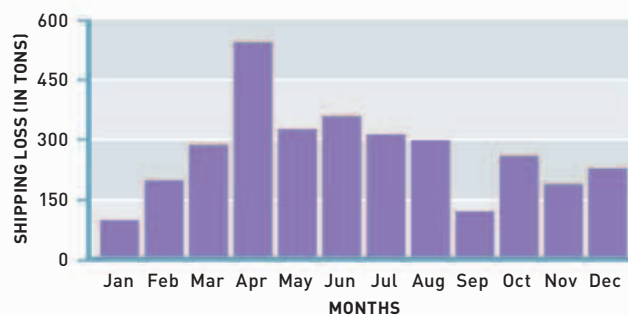


Howitzer Mark I

Used to great effect by the British Army during World War I, this gun could fire two rounds of 290 lb (132 kg) shells every minute.

hydraulic recoil buffer

carriage



British merchant shipping losses to U-boats

German unrestricted submarine warfare increased attacks on merchant ships from February to April. The adoption of a convoy system in May reduced sinkings to a sustainable level.

